The Gupta Period

The eminent rulers of the Gupta empire:

- Chandragupta I (320-335 or 340 CE)
- Samudragupta (nearly 340-380 CE)
- Ramagupta
- Chandragupta II (nearly 380-413 or 415 CE)
- Kumaragupta (near about 415-55 CE)
- Skandagupta (455-467 CE)
- Purugupta (467-469 CE)
- Buddhagupta (477 to nearly 500 CE)

Sources

- Devichandraguptam and the Mudhrarakshasam written by Visakhadutta- provide information regarding the rise of Guptas
- The Chinese traveler Fahein, who visited India during the reign of Chandragupta II, has left a valuable account of the social, economic and religious conditions of the Gupta empire

Inscriptions

- Mehrauli Iron Pillar Inscription refers to the achievements of Chandragupta I
- Allahabad Pillar Inscription- important source for the reign of Samudragupta which describes his personality and achievements. This inscription is engraved on Asokan pillar
- It is written in classical Sanskrit, using the Nagari script
- It consists of 33 lines composed by Harisena which describes the circumstances of Samudragupta's accession, his military campaigns in north India and the Deccan, his relationship with other contemporary rulers, and his accomplishments as a poet and scholar
- Coins issued by Gupta kings contain legends and figures. And provide interesting details about the titles and sacrifices performed by the Gupta monarchs

Chandragupta I (320- 330 CE)

- The founder of the Gupta dynasty was Sri Gupta

- He was succeeded by Ghatotkacha. These two were called Maharajas
- Chandragupta I was the first to be called Maharajadhiraja (the great king of kings)
- He strengthened his position by a matrimonial alliance with the Licchavis. He married Kumaradevi, a princess of that family
- The Mehrauli Iron Pillar inscription mentions his extensive conquests
- Founder of the Gupta era which starts with his accession in 320 CE

Samudragupta (320-380 CE)

- The greatest of the rulers of the Gupta dynasty
- Allahabad pillar provides a detailed account of his reign
- It refers to three stages in his military campaign:
  - Against some rulers of north India- Samudragupta defeated Achyuta (probably a Naga ruler) and Nagasena (belonged to the Kota family). Gained complete mastery over the upper Gangetic valley
  - His famous Dakshinapatha expedition against South Indian rulers- Allahabad pillar inscription mentions that Samudragupta defeated twelve rulers in his South Indian expedition. He defeated the rulers but gave them back their kingdoms and only insisted on them to acknowledge his suzerainty
  - A second campaign against some other rulers of North India to eliminate his remaining north Indian rivals (Nagadatta, Rudradev, Nagasena, Achyuta, Nandin etc)
    - After these military conquests, Samudragupta performed the Asvamedha sacrifices
    - He issued gold and silver coins with the legend 'Restorer of the Asvamedha'
    - Samudragupta was hailed as 'Indian Napoleon' because of his military achievements

Extant of Samudragupta's Empire

- After these conquests, Samudragupta's rule extended over the upper Gangetic valley, the greater part of modern UP, a portion of central India and the southwestern part of Bengal
- Southern influence- the Saka and Kushana principalities on the west and northwest
- Kingdoms on the east coast of the Deccan, as far as the Pallava kingdom, acknowledged his suzerainty

Chandragupta II (380-415 CE)

- He also called himself Vikramaditya
- He extended the Gupta empire by his own conquests by a judicious combination of the policy of diplomacy and warfare
- Through matrimonial alliances he strengthened his political power
  - He married Kuberanaga, a Naga princess of central India
  - He gave his daughter Prabhavati in marriage to the Vakataka prince Rudrasena II (Vakatakas occupied a geographically strategic position in the Deccan)
  - This alliance helped him to campaign in western India against the Sakas
- Conquest of Western India- war against the Saka satraps of western India
  - Rudrasimha III, the last ruler of the Saka satrap was defeated, dethroned and killed and western Malwa and the Kathiawar Peninsula were annexed into the Gupta empire
  - After this victory he performed the horse sacrifice and assumed the title Sakari, meaning, 'destroyer of Sakas'

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